The “Great Stink”

By the early 19th century, London’s Thames was the most polluted river in the world. Industrial pollution and human effluent emptied into it from thousands of drains. People complained, but the government did nothing. In 1855, the scientist Michael Faraday lambasted politicians for their inaction, to no avail. However, they got the message three years later, when a hot summer contributed to the “Great Stink” of 1858. The Houses of Parliament, being adjacent to the Thames, were badly affected, and legislation was suddenly enacted in a mere 18 days.

Civil engineer Joseph Bazalgette was commissioned to design a new sewage system. It was based on six interceptor sewers, 100 miles (160 km) long, which flowed to new treatment works. Most of London was connected to it within a decade. Much of the sewage system is still in operation today, more than 150 years later.